Postsecondary Certificate Trends and Attainment project

Research Progress Report | Week 6

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1 Trends in Credentials, Overall

Figure 1A: Count by credential by year

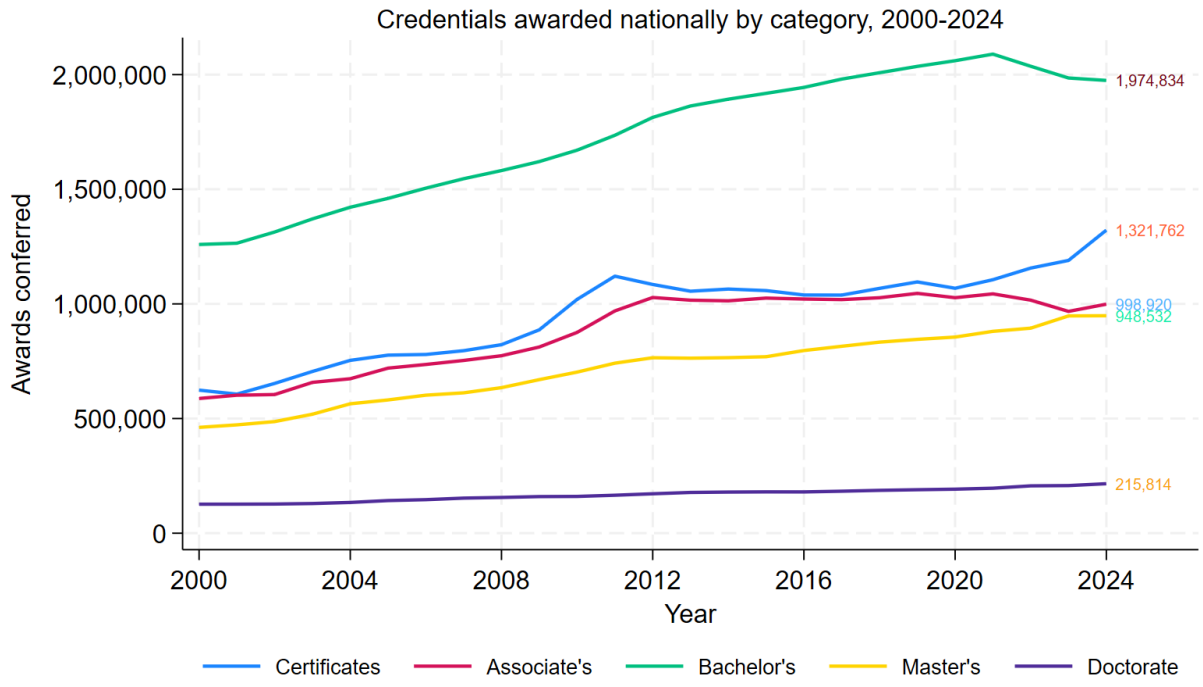


Figure 1: Credentials awarded nationally by category, 2000–2024.

Every category grew over the period, but not by the same amount. Bachelor's degrees stayed the largest category throughout, going from about 1.26 million in 2000 to just under 2 million by 2024. Certificates ended the period as the second-largest category, crossing 1.3 million for the first time in 2024. They tracked associate's degrees closely through the 2000s, then pulled ahead around 2011 and never looked back. Master's degrees grew steadily and by 2024 had nearly caught up with associate's, which is worth noting since the two categories started 130,000 apart in 2000.

Doctorates stayed the smallest category with slow, steady growth.

Figure 1B: Credential share by year

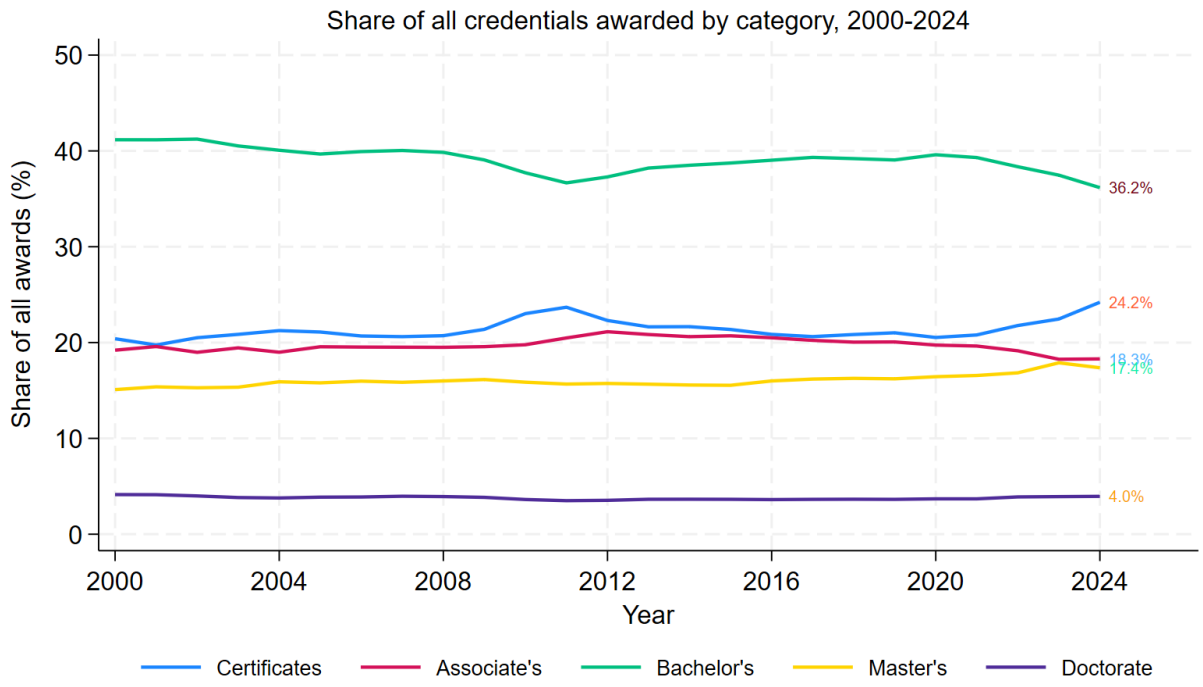


Figure 2: Share of all awards by credential category, 2000–2024.

Figure 1A shows everything growing, so it helps to look at how the mix has shifted. The most notable change is the bachelor's share, which fell from about 41 percent in 2000 to 36 percent in 2024. That share went somewhere, and it went to certificates and master's. Certificates rose from 20 percent to 24 percent by 2024, the highest share of the whole period. Master's rose from 15 percent to 17 percent. Associate's held roughly steady around 19 to 20 percent for most of the period, then slipped to 18 percent in the last two years. Doctorate's share barely moved at all, hovering around 4 percent throughout. The overall picture is a slow shift away from bachelor's degrees toward shorter credentials and graduate-level ones.

Figure 1C: Certificate count by year, by type

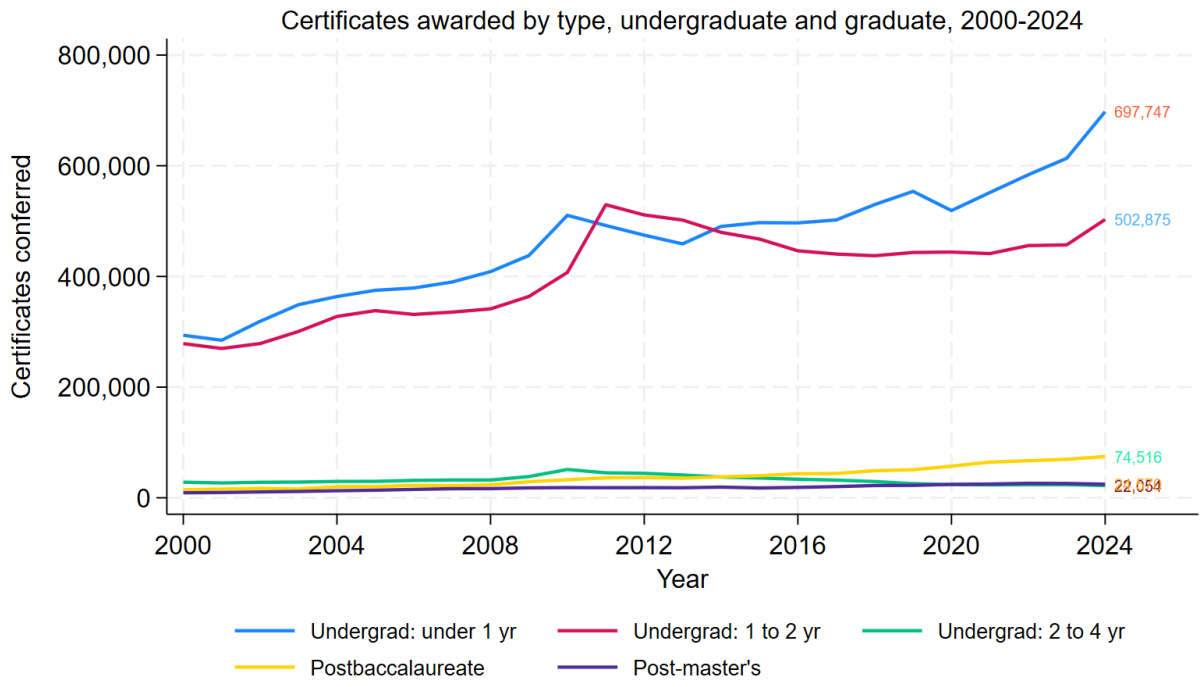


Figure 3: Certificates awarded by type and by undergraduate versus graduate, 2000–2024.

Zooming in on certificates alone shows that two undergraduate categories do most of the work. Under-one-year certificates are the biggest and fastest-growing group. They went from about 294,000 in 2000 to 698,000 in 2024, more than doubling, with a clear jump around the 2011 recession years and another sharp acceleration after 2020. Undergraduate one-to-two-year certificates grew from 279,000 to 503,000. The other three categories are much smaller but tell interesting stories of their own. Two-to-four-year undergraduate certificates stayed essentially flat. Post-master's certificates grew modestly, from 9,000 to 25,000. The category worth flagging is postbaccalaureate certificates, which grew from 15,000 to 75,000, a fivefold increase. That's the fastest growth rate in the panel and points to something real happening in short credentials aimed at people who already have a bachelor's degree.

2 Length

Figure 2: Count by type of under-1-year certificate by year

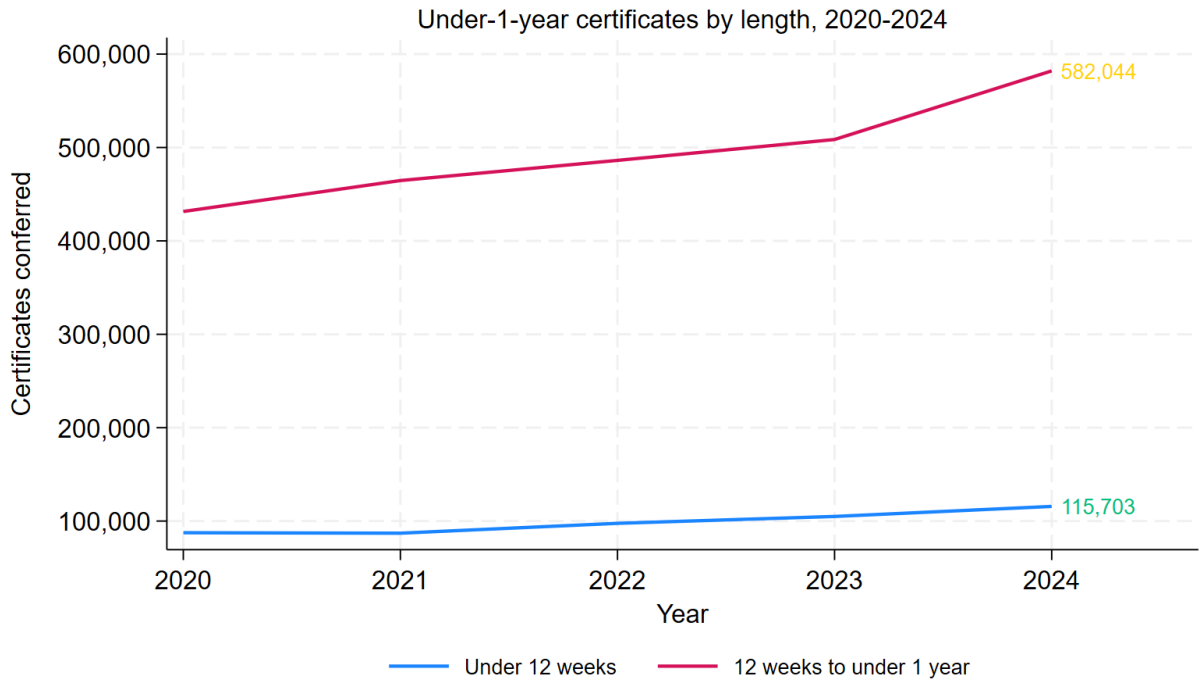


Figure 4: Under-1-year certificates split by length, 2020–2024.

Starting in 2020, IPEDS began reporting under-1-year certificates in two separate buckets: those that take less than 12 weeks, and those that take 12 weeks to under a year. Before 2020, both were reported together under a single code, so the split is only available for the last five years of the panel. Even in this short window, the direction is clear. The 12-weeks-to-1-year category is by far the larger of the two, going from 432,000 in 2020 to 582,000 in 2024, a jump of about 35 percent in five years. The under-12-weeks category is smaller but not trivial, growing from 88,000 to about 116,000 over the same period, about 32 percent. Both are climbing at roughly the same pace, which suggests the recent boom in short credentials is not driven by one length or the other but by growth across the whole under-1-year space. This is worth keeping an eye on because Workforce Pell, if enacted, would likely accelerate the under-12-weeks category specifically since that is the length range the policy is designed to reach.

3 Sector

Figure 3A: Count of under-1-year certificates by sector, undergraduate

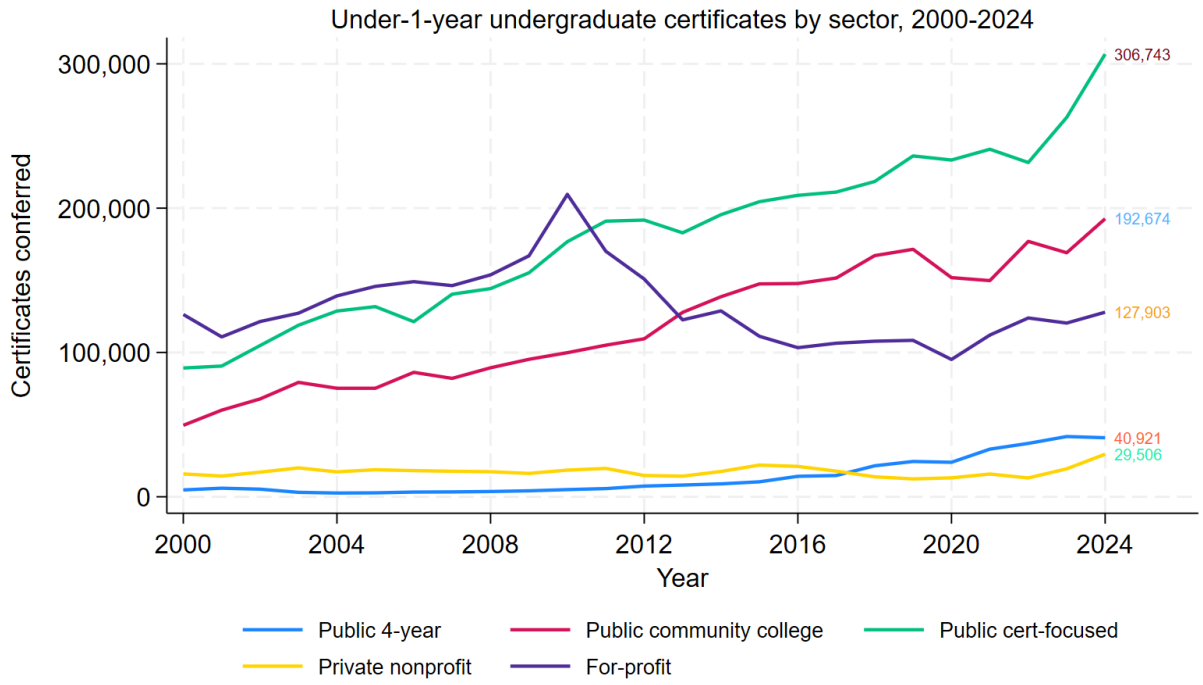


Figure 5: Under-1-year undergraduate certificates by sector, 2000–2024.

The under-1-year undergraduate certificate market has been through a major reshuffle. In 2000, for-profit institutions were the biggest producer at about 125,000 certificates, followed by public cert-focused schools at 90,000 and public community colleges at 50,000. Then the for-profit line peaked at 210,000 in 2010 and dropped sharply through the following decade, ending at 128,000 in 2024. In the meantime, the two public sectors kept climbing. Public cert-focused institutions more than tripled to 307,000, and public community colleges nearly quadrupled to 193,000. Public 4-year universities are a smaller player in absolute terms but grew from almost nothing to about 41,000. Private nonprofits stayed a minor producer throughout. Two things worth noting: the for-profit collapse lines up with the tighter federal regulation of the sector after 2011, and public institutions across all three types have absorbed most of that lost volume.

Figure 3B: Sector share of under-1-year certificates, undergraduate

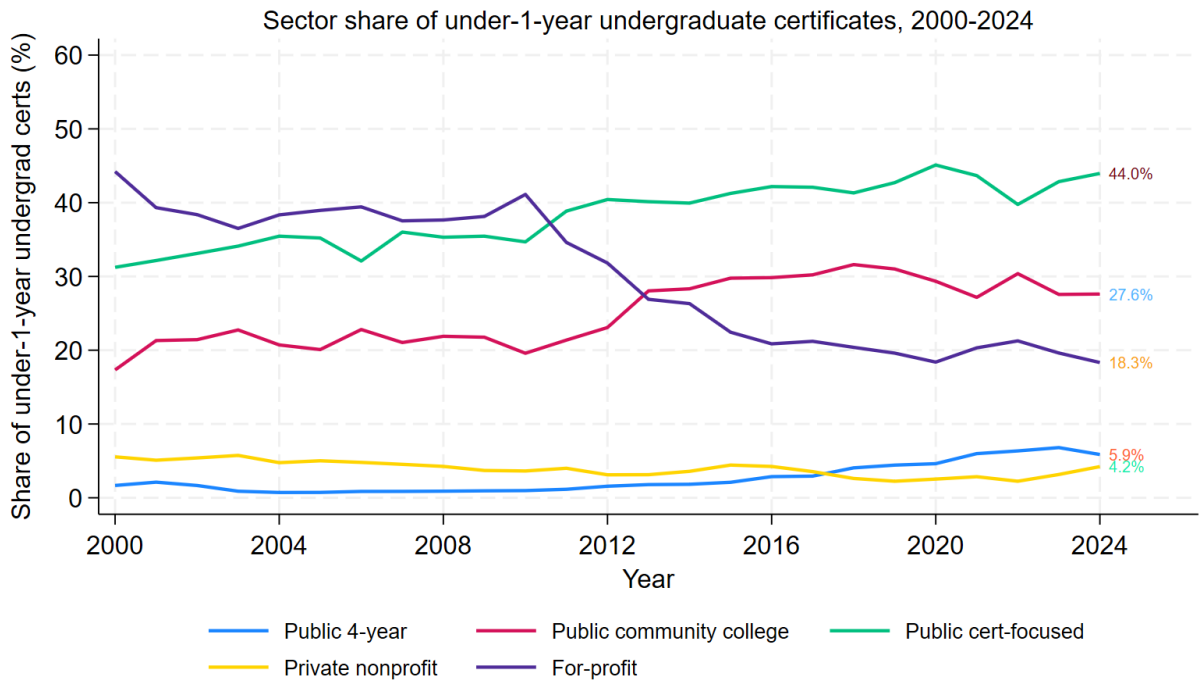


Figure 6: Sector share of under-1-year undergraduate certificates, 2000–2024.

Looking at the same data as shares makes the shift easier to see. In 2000, for-profits held about 44 percent of the under-1-year undergraduate certificate market, and the three public sectors combined held roughly half. By 2024, for-profits are down to 18 percent, and the public share has grown to about 78 percent. Within the public sectors, cert-focused institutions became the single largest producer at 44 percent, up from 31 percent. Public community colleges hold 28 percent, up from 17 percent. Public 4-year universities grew from under 2 percent to about 6 percent, which is small but represents real growth given they are not traditionally associated with certificate production. This chart is the clearest visual of the sector-level story: the certificate market went from a mixed public-and-for-profit space to one that is now overwhelmingly public.

Figure 3C: Count of graduate certificates by sector

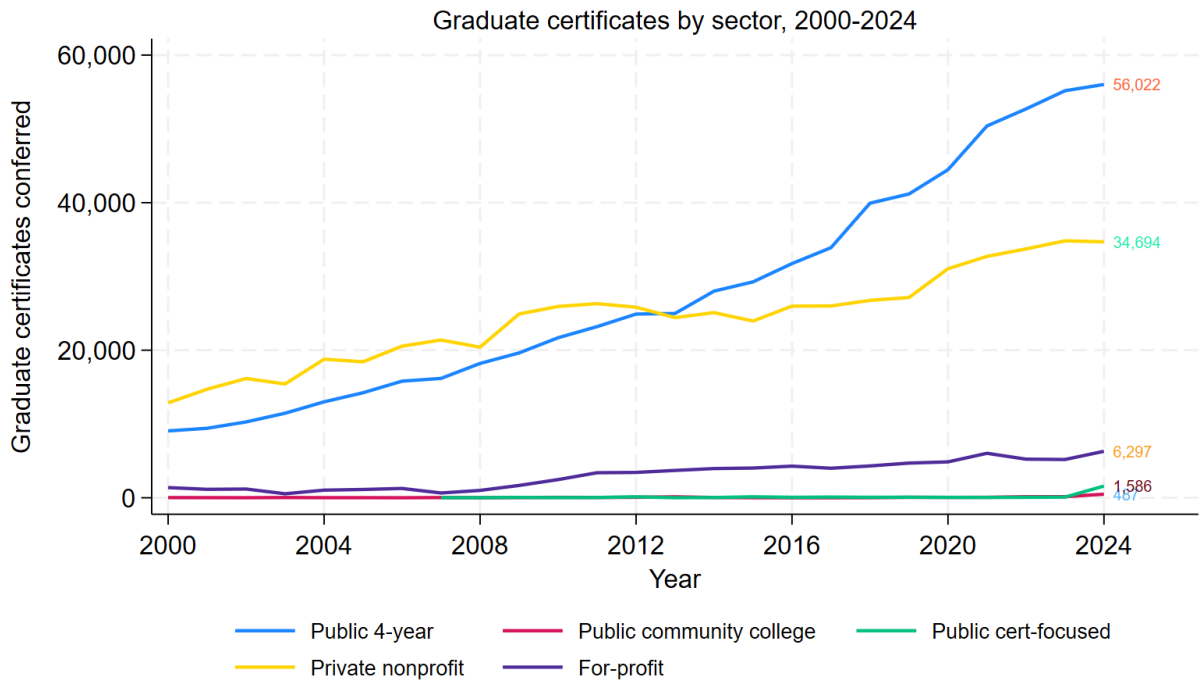


Figure 7: Graduate certificates by sector, 2000–2024.

Graduate certificates are a much smaller market than undergraduate ones, but the growth has been substantial. Public 4-year universities are the story here. They went from about 9,000 graduate certificates in 2000 to 56,000 in 2024, a six-fold increase. Private nonprofit institutions, which are also mostly 4-year universities, grew from 13,000 to 35,000. Public 4-year universities overtook private nonprofits as the largest producer of graduate certificates around 2013 and have kept pulling ahead since. For-profit graduate certificates grew modestly from a base of roughly 1,500 to about 6,000. Public community colleges and public cert-focused institutions produce almost no graduate certificates, which makes sense given their mission. The pattern is consistent with universities adding short credentials for people who already hold bachelor's or master's degrees, likely as a way to package specific skills into a formal credential.

Figure 3D: Sector share of graduate certificates

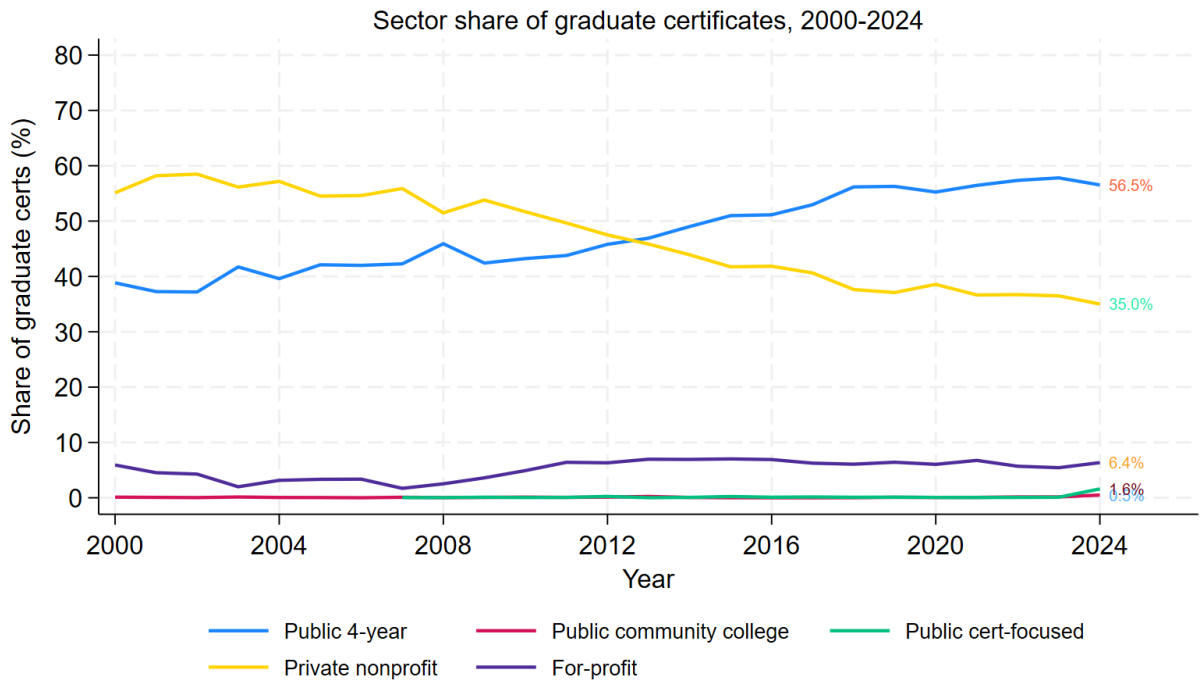


Figure 8: Sector share of graduate certificates, 2000–2024.

The share picture reinforces what Figure 3C shows. In 2000, private nonprofit universities held about 55 percent of the graduate certificate market, and public 4-year universities held 39 percent. The lines crossed around 2013 and kept moving in opposite directions. By 2024, public 4-year universities hold 57 percent of the market and private nonprofits hold 35 percent. For-profits hold about 6 percent, and the other public sectors are essentially absent. The takeaway is that graduate certificate production has become a public university product over the past decade, which is a shift that has gotten less attention than the undergraduate story but is happening in parallel.

4 Geography

Figure 4A: State map, certificate-to-associate degree ratio, 2024

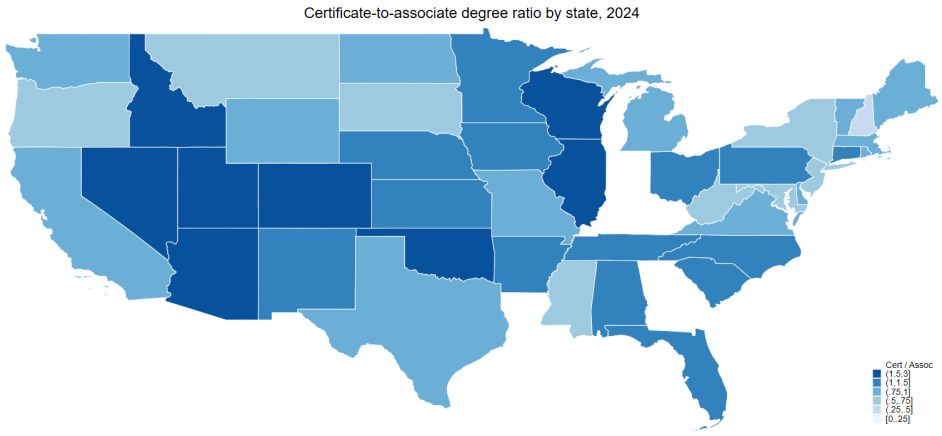


Figure 9: Certificate-to-associate degree ratio by state, 2024.

The ratio here is simply the number of undergraduate certificates a state awarded in 2024 divided by the number of associate degrees. A ratio above 1 means the state produces more certificates than associate degrees, and a ratio below 1 means the opposite. The map shows that this varies a lot across the country. Certificate-heavy states cluster in the Mountain West, the Midwest, and parts of the South. Idaho, Utah, Wisconsin, Illinois, Louisiana, Georgia, and Oklahoma all are at ratios above 1.5, meaning they produce well over one and a half certificates for every associate degree. New England, West Virginia, and Mississippi are on the low end, producing far more associate degrees than certificates. Kentucky is in the darker range, which fits with what the next figure shows.

Figure 4B: State-level trends in the certificate-to-associate ratio, 2000–2024

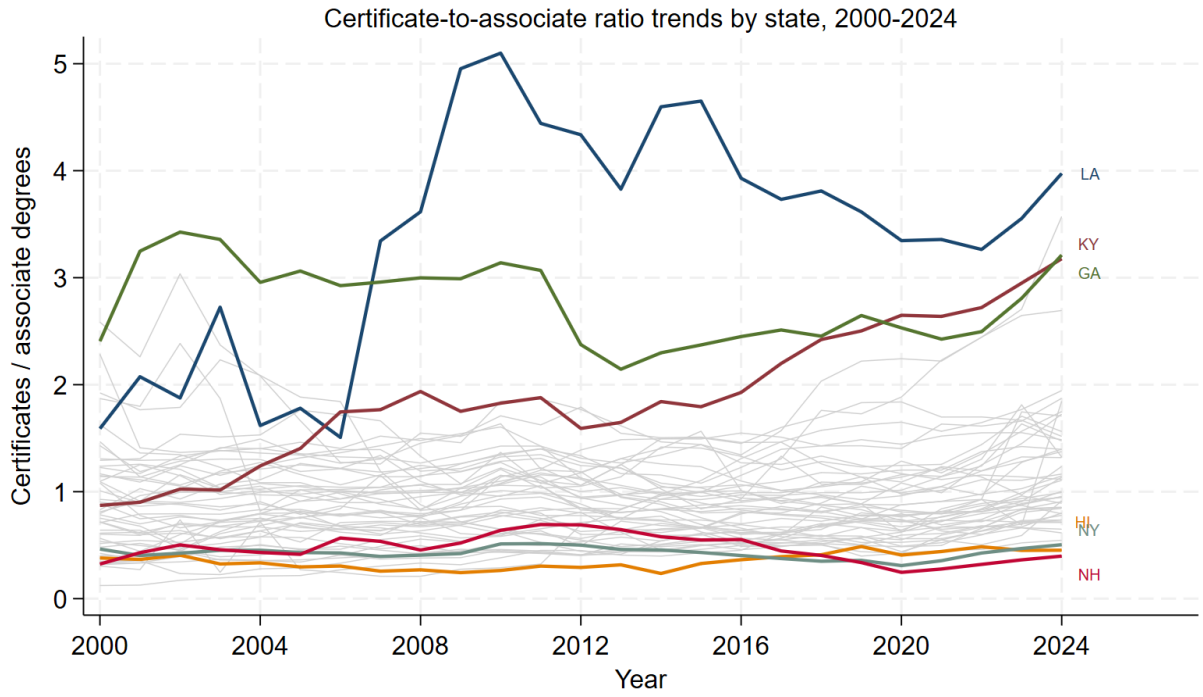


Figure 10: Certificate-to-associate ratio trends by state, 2000–2024.

The gray lines are the other 44 states, shown as background context. Six states are highlighted: the three highest and three lowest by 2024 ratio, plus Kentucky. What stands out is that most states have not really changed much over 25 years. New Hampshire, New York, and Hawaii have all stayed near the bottom of the distribution. Georgia and Louisiana have both stayed high, though Louisiana peaked around 5.1 in 2010 before drifting down and settling around 4 in 2024. The one state that really transformed is Kentucky. It started at a ratio of about 0.9 in 2000, which put it near the middle of the pack, and climbed steadily to 3.2 by 2024. That is one of the largest transitions in the whole country over this period, and it makes Kentucky one of only a handful of states that meaningfully changed its credential mix during this window.

Figure 4C: Certificate-to-associate ratio at community colleges, by locale

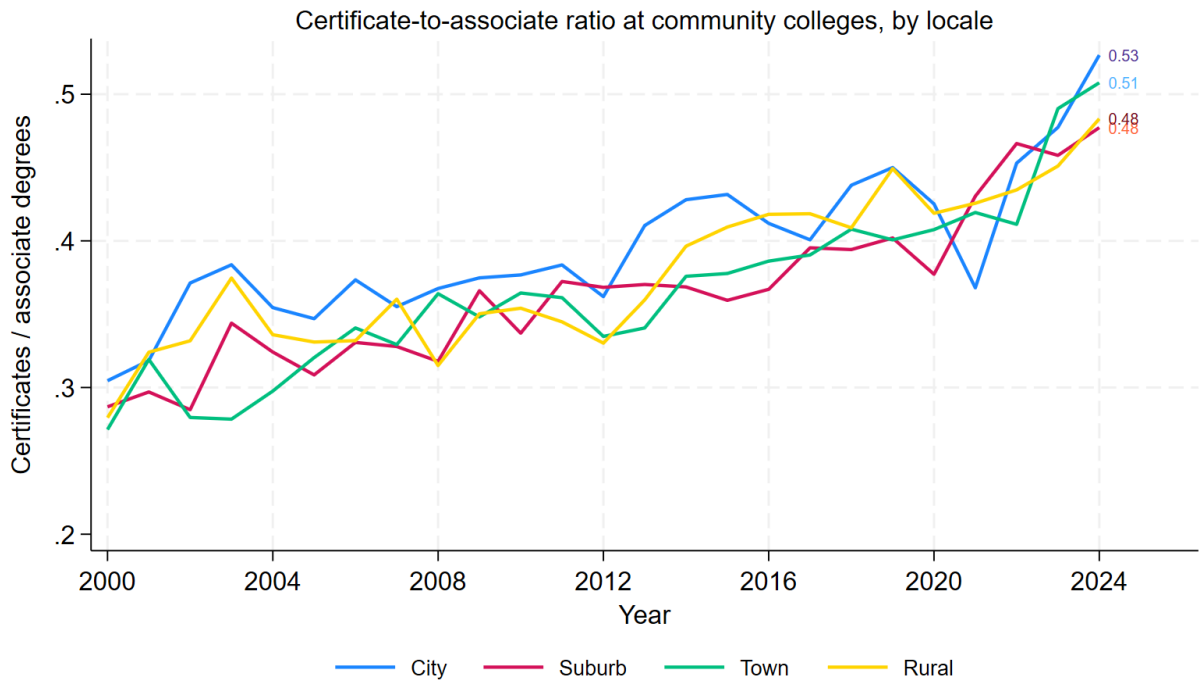


Figure 11: Certificate-to-associate ratio at community colleges, by urban-rural locale, 2000–2024.

This one shows whether rural community colleges are doing something different from urban ones on the certificate-to-associate front. The short answer is no. All four locale types (city, suburb, town, rural) started around 0.30 in 2000 and moved together up to about 0.48 to 0.53 by 2024. City community colleges are marginally higher than the rest by 2024, but the differences are small enough that any story about rural community colleges being distinct on this measure would not hold up. If anything, the more interesting fact here is that all community colleges, regardless of their locations, have shifted meaningfully toward certificates over the last 25 years. The ratio has gone up by about two-thirds across the board.

5 Field

Figure 5: Undergraduate certificates by 2-digit field, 2024 (treemap)

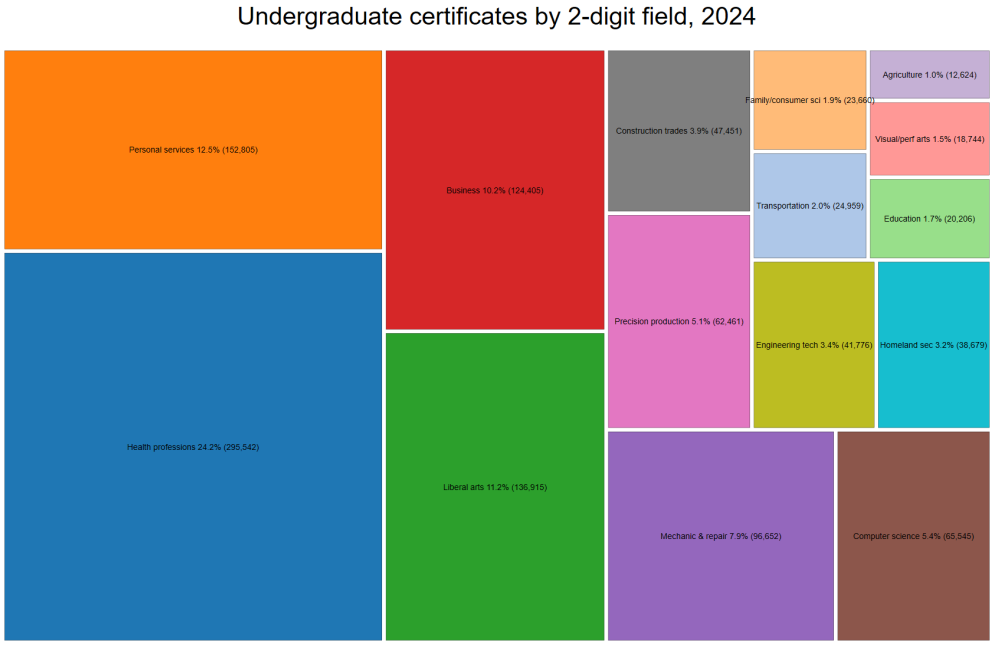


Figure 12: Undergraduate certificates by 2-digit CIP field, 2024. Each rectangle is sized by that field's share of total undergraduate certificates.

Certificates cluster in a small number of fields. Health professions is the single largest at 24.2 percent of all undergraduate certificates, followed by personal services (mostly cosmetology and related programs) at 12.5 percent and liberal arts and general studies at 11.2 percent. Business, mechanic and repair, computer science, and precision production round out the next tier, each between 5 and 11 percent. Everything below that is small, but the long tail matters cumulatively. The top five fields alone account for about two-thirds of all undergraduate certificates.

Figure 5A (alternate): Same data as a horizontal bar chart

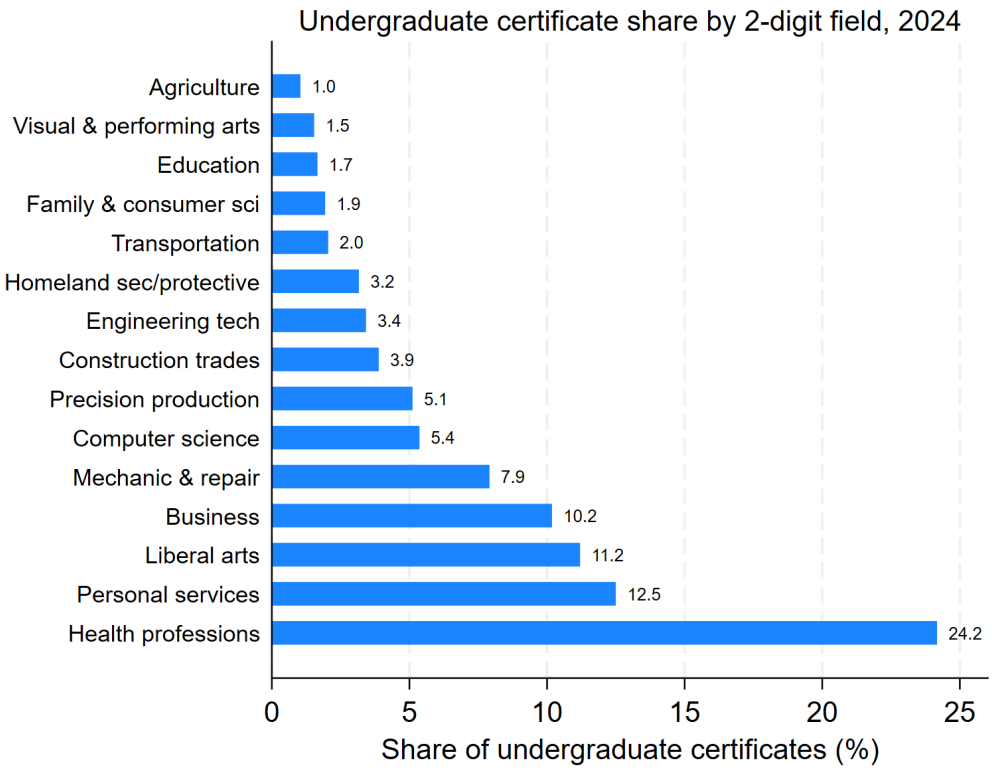


Figure 13: Undergraduate certificate share by 2-digit CIP field, 2024.

This is the same information as the treemap in a bar chart form. Sharing both because the treemap gives a nice at-a-glance sense of proportions, while the bar chart is easier to read for exact comparisons across fields. Either one could work for the final version, and it might be worth picking based on how the section reads once it is all together.

Figure 5: Field composition of undergraduate certificates over time

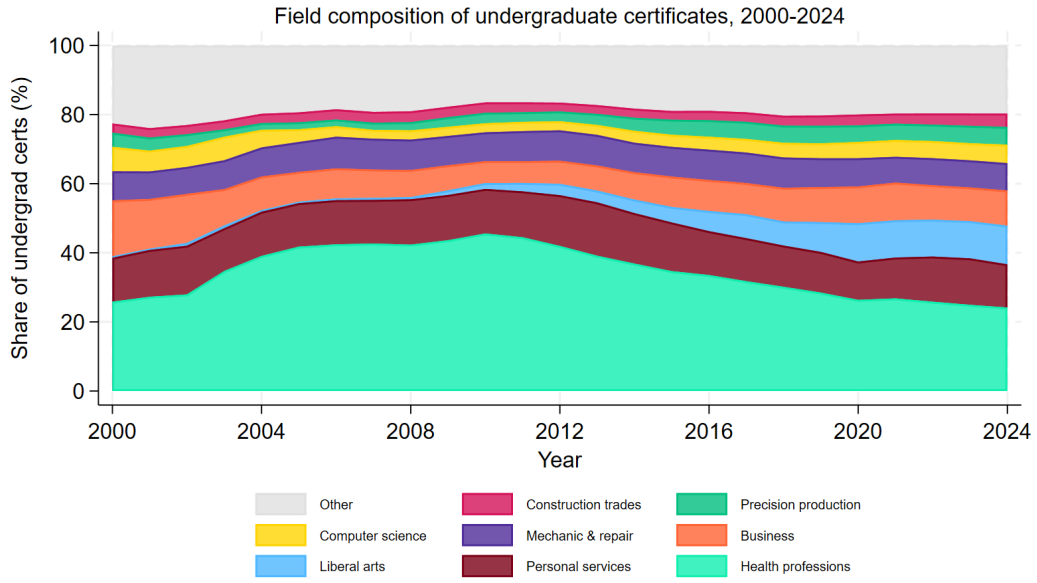


Figure 14: Share of undergraduate certificates by top 8 CIP fields, 2000–2024.

This shows how the certificate mix has shifted over 25 years. The top 8 fields by 2024 share are stacked, with everything else grouped into the gray "Other" band at the top. The most striking change is health professions. It made up about 26 percent of certificates in 2000, climbed to 45 percent by 2010 during the recession-era boom, and then dropped back down to 24 percent by 2024. The rise and fall is one of the clearest field-level stories in the whole panel. On the way up, liberal arts filled some of the space health left behind, growing from a tiny share to a visible one by 2024. Personal services (cosmetology and related) held roughly steady in the 10 to 15 percent range for most of the period. Mechanic and repair, business, and computer science have all been relatively flat as shares. The takeaway is that the certificate market is less concentrated in health today than it was ten years ago, but the redistribution has spread across a mix of fields rather than moving into any single one.

Data, Code, and Figures Availability

Everything used in this report, including the raw and cleaned data files, codes, and figures are available in the GitHub repository. Anyone with access can rerun everything from the raw files through the final outputs and reproduce these results.